

Structured decision making and community engagement

CUNY EES 79903

Seminar on Nature-Based Solutions

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Lecture Overview:

- Key Messages and Traceable Accounts
- Mini Lecture: Community Engagement and SDM
- Discussion: Ibrahim et al. (2025), Pathak et al. (2026), Crawford et al. (2026)
- Example of stakeholder goals

Format of Projects

<https://nysclimateimpacts.org/about-the-assessment/methods-and-sources/>

- **Key findings** represent important takeaways identified by the student teams. They attempt to convey:
- **The “What?”** Current challenges, circumstances, facts, observations, and projections.
- **The “So what?”** The implications and meaning, including underlying assumptions.
- **The “Now what?”** Potential actions, trade-offs, and resources needed to address the challenges, as well as knowledge gaps.
- Key findings focus on impacts, responses, and solutions.
- **Traceable accounts** provide supporting evidence for each of the key findings. They describe supporting information and the level of confidence in each finding, allowing interested readers to “trace” the rationale and information sources used to develop each finding. Traceable accounts must include:
 - The evidence that supports each key finding, including references and sources
 - The quality of the evidence
 - The level of agreement in the literature
 - Key uncertainties
- Each topic would include 3-5 key messages, with 1-2 paragraphs in the traceable account for each key message.

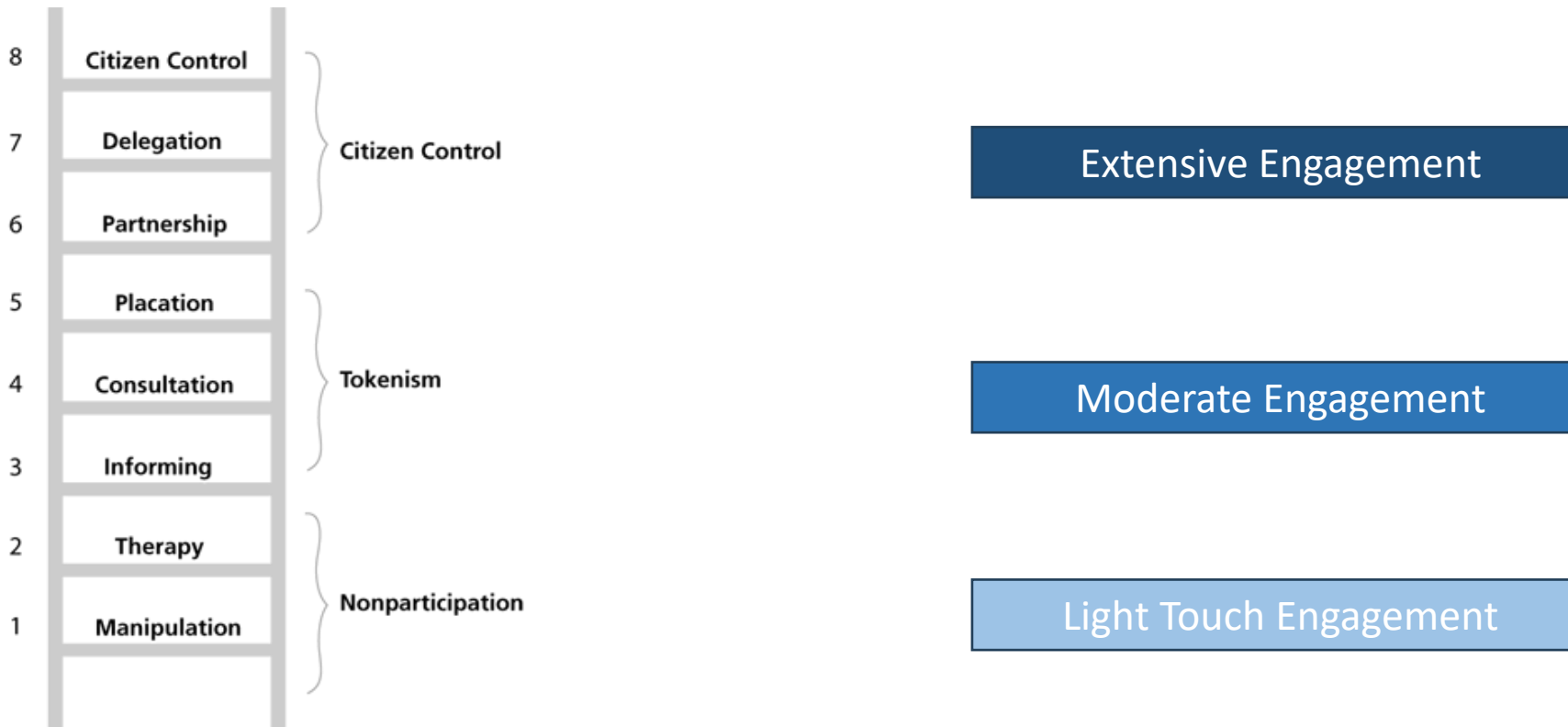
Terminology

- **“Community”** may be defined in a number of ways. Community boundaries may be based on legal, political, physical, or symbolic criteria. Most often for NNBf projects, the term “community” refers to a geographical and administrative designation in that there are physical boundaries around a place that operates with a governance structure (e.g., town, city, or county).
- **Stakeholders** are individuals, groups, or organizations that have a relevant interest (e.g., political or legal) and that could impact, be impacted by, or influence the issue or project. Stakeholders include communities and members of the public, as well as charities, campaign or public interest groups, and public- and private-sector organizations. It is important to make a distinction between opinions and interests.

Starting with terminology

- **Outreach vs Engagement** – what differentiates them?

Arnstein's ladder of citizen participation

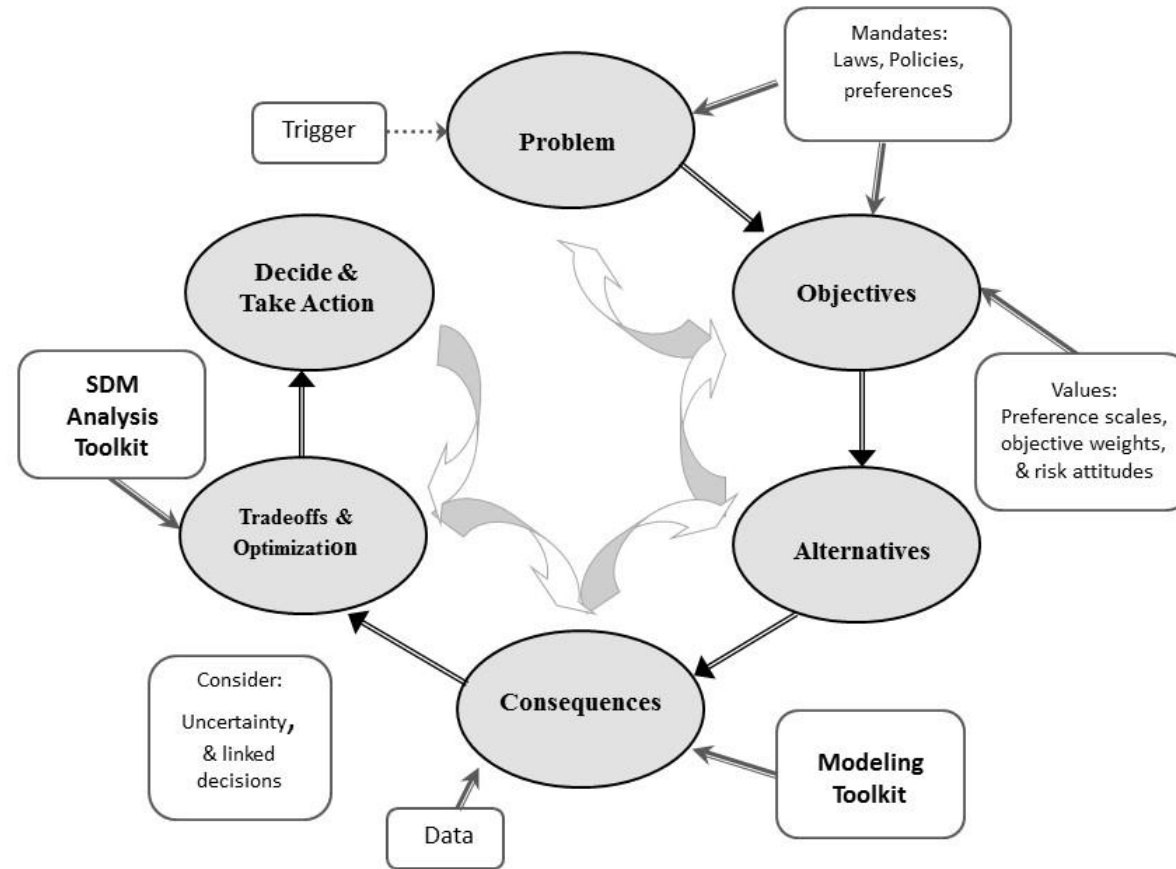


Arnstein's Ladder (1969)
Degrees of Citizen Participation

Structured Decision Making

- Careful and organized analysis of natural resource management decisions.
- Based in decision theory and risk analysis
- Key SDM concepts include making decisions based on
 - clearly articulated fundamental objectives,
 - recognizing the role of scientific predictions in decisions,
 - dealing explicitly with uncertainty, and
 - responding transparently to societal values in decision making;
- SDM integrates science and policy explicitly
- Every decision consists of several primary elements – management objectives, decision options, and predictions of decision outcomes.
- Multi-criteria decision analysis (MCDA) is a process within SDM

Structured Decision Making



Source: Jean Fitts Cochrane